

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Daniel

Daniel

As Daniel was becoming a young man, Babylon was becoming strong and rich. At the same time, the people of Israel were being forced to leave Judah and live in Babylonia. Could God's people ever live again as the Lord's chosen nation?

Through Daniel's life as a captive and a government official, God showed Daniel his power and his plan for history. God also gave Daniel special messages. These showed that God would rescue his people from exile. He would even rescue them from death.

Setting

In 605 BC, Nebuchadnezzar II, king of Babylon, attacked Jerusalem. He took some Israelites to Babylon as captives. This included some young men from Judah's royal family (1:1-4).

Through this event, God began to send his people into exile, as he had warned. The Israelites had broken faith with God. They had broken his covenant, which was his binding agreement with them (Deuteronomy 28:36, 64; Jeremiah 11:1-17; 25:11-12; 29:10-11). God used the powerful king Nebuchadnezzar to judge his people Israel (Jeremiah 25:9).

During this time, Daniel and his friends began training ordered by Nebuchadnezzar. This training was meant to make them live like Babylonians. It threatened to pull them away from their identity as the Lord's holy people, set apart for him (see Exodus 19:5-6).

At the same time, the Babylonians continued to destroy Judah and Jerusalem. In 597 BC, they took more Israelites to Babylon. In 586 BC, they destroyed Jerusalem. After 586 BC, Judah was no longer a nation.

God's people were weak and without hope. At this very low point, they became "the tail" of the nations, not "the head," as God had warned (see Deuteronomy 28:13, 44). It seemed that Babylon might absorb them completely. They could have disappeared from history.

God had promised that Abraham's descendants would bless all nations. But now that promise seemed impossible (Genesis 12:1-3). The great Gentile powers of the ancient Near East ruled the world. First Assyria ruled. Then Babylon ruled.

What would happen to Israel in exile? What would happen to God's promises to Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, and David (Exodus 19-20; 2 Samuel 7:1-29)?

Would God act on the hopeful words he had spoken through his prophets? How would God rescue his people from exile?

Daniel stayed faithful to God. He honored his people and brought glory to God. He did this through the rule of several Babylonian kings, until the end of the Babylonian exile. While God's people suffered the "death of exile" (Ezekiel 37), God showed Daniel visions about the future. In these visions, a coming King would receive power and rule forever.

In 539 BC, Cyrus of Persia surprised the world by invading Babylon. He entered the capital city and defeated it. He also defeated its evil ruler, Belshazzar. This happened just as the prophet Isaiah had said (Isaiah 44:26-45:7). Daniel witnessed the announcement that allowed captive peoples to return to their homes (see Ezra 1:2-4). This fulfilled Jeremiah's prophecy and answered Daniel's prayer from earlier that same year (Jeremiah 25:11-12; 29:10-11; Daniel 9:1-19). After 70 years of serving foreign rulers, God's people were being restored.

The Lord gave his holy people hope for the future through Daniel. God used visions and dreams to show his plan for history. God spoke to give his people new hope as they faced a difficult and dangerous future.

Summary

The book of Daniel covers the years from 605 BC to about 535 BC.

Chapters 1-6 tell about events that show God's faithfulness to Daniel and his friends. They stayed faithful to God and his law. Three times, the Hebrew captives faced royal commands that went against God's law (chapters 1, 3, 6). Each time, they showed wisdom and obeyed God. God saved them from harm. Three times, God spoke through Daniel to explain messages he had given to pagan kings (chapters 2, 4, 5). Daniel's words, and the events that followed, showed that God has final power and authority over the earth.

In chapters 7-12, the focus shifts to God's rule over all history. Chapter 7 uses animals as symbols. It tells the same main story as chapter 2. World history will end with the coming of God's kingdom. But first, there will be strong opposition to God and his purposes.

Chapter 8 focuses on Persia and Greece. It ends by describing the actions of a wicked ruler who opposes God's people.

Chapter 9 includes Daniel's wonderful prayer. Jeremiah's prophecy about 70 years of serving foreign rulers led Daniel to pray (9:1-2). God heard Daniel's

prayer, and the exile came to an end. Because Daniel prayed, the angel Gabriel came to him. Gabriel revealed the coming “seventy weeks” (or “70 sevens”), a period in God’s plan. This vision showed how God would strengthen his people and deal with those who oppressed them.

In chapters 10–12, the book ends with a final vision. This vision shows history from the third year of Cyrus in 536 BC, through the time of Greece and Rome, and on to the resurrection, when the dead will rise. Daniel was faithful to his calling. God promised that Daniel “will arise ... at the end of days” (12:13).

Author and Date

Scholars have long debated when the book of Daniel reached its final form. Most conservative scholars believe Daniel wrote the book in the late 500s BC. The book presents itself as prophecy, a message from God about future events (2:29–31; 4:24; 7:1–12:13). The author also places Daniel in the 500s BC (2:1; 5:1; 10:1). The book shows strong knowledge of Babylonian history. However, some historical issues remain.

Other scholars say the book was written around 164 BC. They give this date mainly because Daniel describes events up to about that time. They believe the predictions in 11:1–35 are too detailed to have been given 300 years before the events happened. These events took place between 190 and 164 BC.

However, there are problems with rejecting an early date for Daniel. Most importantly, the book in its final form clearly presents Daniel as its author. A late date assumes that Daniel could not have written it. But if Daniel did not write the prophecies about the future, then the book’s claims become difficult to trust. It would also be hard to explain why it was accepted into the Hebrew canon.

One of Daniel’s main claims is that God can reveal the future (2:27–29; 10:21). The details in these prophecies are remarkable. But this does not mean they are impossible. God can reveal the future to his prophets with as much detail as he chooses.

Daniel’s visions share traits with apocalyptic literature, a kind of writing that uses visions and symbols to show God’s final victory over evil and to give hope to his people. This kind of writing was especially common in Jewish writings from the time between the Old and New Testaments, after 400 BC. Because of this, some scholars say Daniel could not have been written before that time. However, recent studies argue that apocalyptic ideas are already present in biblical books from

the exile. Because of this, Daniel may have served as a model for later apocalyptic writings.

In summary, it is reasonable to believe that Daniel himself wrote the book of Daniel in the 500s BC. The arguments for a later author are not without problems. The traditional view also fits the book’s message. Daniel presents itself as inspired prophecy, a message from God that tells about future events.

Daniel as Literature

Daniel includes history, but it teaches more than history. It shows the theological meaning of history. This means it shows what earthly events reveal about God and his purposes. Daniel shows God’s power and plan in history through the way it tells these events.

Daniel as Wisdom Literature

Daniel is a wisdom book. It teaches God’s people how to live wisely in God’s ways.

A wise person is made pure through suffering. A wise person seeks the way of righteousness, which means living in a way that pleases God. A wise person also leads others to live in that way (11:33–35; 12:3). A wise person knows that God Most High rules over all gods. God knows and controls the future. He can rescue his people from any danger (3:16–18; 6:21–22; 12:1–3).

Daniel As Apocalyptic Literature

Some parts of Daniel are apocalyptic literature. Apocalyptic literature uses visions and symbols to reveal God’s work in history.

The word apocalyptic comes from the Greek word *apokalypsis*, which means “revelation.” This kind of writing shows what people cannot normally see. It reveals the work of God, angels, and other spiritual powers. These spiritual powers affect events on earth.

Apocalyptic literature often uses strong symbols. For example, statues, animals, or horns may stand for kings, kingdoms, or people.

It is important to interpret apocalyptic literature by asking what its images mean. What truth do the images show?

To understand these symbols well, people must study the passage’s literary context and historical background. Literary context means the verses and chapters around a passage. Historical background means the events and culture connected to it.

Sometimes the text itself explains the images (7:1–14, 16–17, 23–25). At other times, readers need to study the social, political, military, or cultural setting. For

example, the history of Babylon can help explain why Babylon is pictured as a golden head or a lion.

The book of Daniel teaches theological lessons, which are truths about God. It does this by showing the deeper meaning of earthly events.

The Text of Daniel

The ancient Greek version of Daniel and the Latin Vulgate include three passages not found in the Hebrew manuscripts. These passages are included in Roman Catholic and Orthodox editions of the Bible, but not in Protestant editions.

Meaning and Message

Daniel's main theme is that God is sovereign, which means God rules over all things. God will complete his purposes for people and for all creation. History is moving toward the kingdom of God. In that kingdom, everyone will fully see and know God's rule.

God judges and rescues his people. God rules over all history and all nations. God raises up pagan kingdoms and kings, and he brings them down. God decided when the exile would end (9:18–19). God also defeats and controls the powers of evil (4:30, 32; 7:8, 20–21; 10:13; 11:28, 30–32). Heavenly beings bow before God (3:28; 4:23, 35; 5:5; 6:21; 8:16; 9:21; 10:5, 13; 12:1). God also has power to raise the dead (12:1–3).

God's wisdom rules over all things (3:18; 11:35). God chooses and approves those who are beloved and greatly valued in his sight (9:23; 10:11, 19). God will establish his kingdom over all the earth forever. God's people will rule with their King, the Son of Man (7:13, 22; see Psalm 110:1; Matthew 24:27–44; 25:31; 26:2, 64; Mark 14:62; Revelation 1:7).